

The Battle of Sabine Pass

The Union went on the offensive in Texas as well, occupying the major port of Galveston in October 1862. Having then lost the port to a miraculous Confederate counterattack on January 1, 1863, Major General Benjamin Butler, commanding Union forces in New Orleans, decided to retake it.

On September 7, four gunboats, 19 transports, and 5,000 bluecoats arrived offshore from Sabine Pass, which commanded a seaborne approach toward Galveston. There were only 47 Southern gunners in the main fort commanding the pass, but they had relieved their boredom over the previous months with target practice. Each of the guns was accurately registered to hit a designated target in the Texas Channel. The practice paid off when, waiting patiently until the Union gunboats passed directly by those targets, the Confederate commander suddenly ordered his six guns to open fire. The Union ships were pummeled with direct hits that put the first two gunboats out of action and blocked the channel.

Instead of landing the infantry at an alternate location, the Yankees were overawed by the fierce defense, and turned their remaining boats around, sailing back to New Orleans. Jefferson Davis and the Confederate Congress acclaimed Sabine Pass as a glorious victory and pumped up its significance to help restore lagging Southern morale. Special medals for each of the 47 gunners were struck to commemorate the heroic defense, and Galveston eventually remained the only major Southern port still under Confederate control at the end of the war.